

Assalamualaikum brother Bilal,

I've been wanting to put this into words for a while.

I still remember the first day we met at your house. You didn't give me a lecture or a sales pitch, you just asked me, gently, if I wanted to pray with you. That one simple invite changed everything. When we finished, I felt a calm I hadn't felt in a long time, and I trusted you immediately, like my heart finally found a place to rest mashallah.

That same day I told you the truth, how dark it had been, how suicidal I felt, how tired I was of fighting it alone. You didn't flinch. You sat with me in it. You listened, you reminded me that Allah is Near, and you helped me take the next right step instead of trying to solve everything at once. You didn't just say "I'm here for you" but you proved it.

Islam saved my life, but Allah sent me to it through you. The fundraiser Imam Khalid started, the community that rallied, the duas, the check-ins, you helped open those doors. And then you made your own shahada. Seeing you join Islam felt like witnessing a sunrise from the same mountain we'd been climbing together. Mashallah I'm so proud of you brother.

You are my brother, not just in friendship, but in faith. The best brother I could ask for. I ask Allah to keep our hearts steadfast, to make our prayers light our path, and to let us meet him with clean hearts, side by side.

JazakAllahu khayran for leading me to the prayer mat, for staying when the room was heavy, and for choosing this path with me. May every good you showed me be written for you many times over.

Walaikum salam,

Sammy